

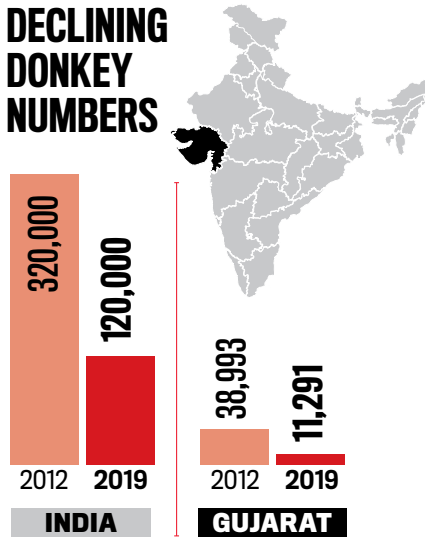
AFP

the donkey continues to fulfil a need around rural brick kilns and in transporting goods in challenging terrain, like Pavagadh and Palitana. Beyond its arid stretches, they remain essential for military operations in mountainous regions. But it's a vastly reduced role, and it shows in the waning interest of traders in the humble draught animal.

Akshay Vanzara and his brother Ashaji were relieved when the Vautha fair drew to a close in late November. They had travelled over 100 km from Surendranager in Saurashtra with two donkeys that they sold for a modest Rs 20,000 each—the same price as last year. In their late 20s, the siblings represent the fourth generation of their family engaged in the transportation of materials and debris for the construction industry. However, unlike their ancestors, Akshay and Ashaji operate tractors. They are rather baffled by the continued tradition of keeping donkeys and participating in the fair. As for Dharmendra Vanzara of Jethlaj village in Kalol taluka of Gandhinagar, he no longer concerns himself with the fair. He let the last of his donkeys go 15 years ago and has no regrets. "We discontinued their use in 2008. I used to have 10 of them; now, I own 10 large dumpers and do 20 times the business," he says.

THE ABSENCE OF A FORMAL INDUSTRY HAS EXPOSED THE DONKEYS TO THE THREAT OF SURVIVAL THROUGH SMUGGLING FOR THEIR SKIN

DECLINING DONKEY NUMBERS



Source: Livestock census

The Vautha fair serves as a window to the changing dynamics of the rural economy and culture, and its impact on ecology. The decline in donkeys' economic utility raises legitimate concerns as their potential inclusion in the endangered species list looms large. Gujarat, primarily, has two breeds—Halari and Kutchi. The Halari breed comes from Jamnagar in Saurashtra while the Kutchi is from the arid desert region of Kutch. Notably, both breeds are characterised by their compact size, rendering them unsuitable for military purposes and limiting their effectiveness for brick kilns.

Dr Dhirendra Kapadiya, deputy director of the state animal husbandry department, reveals plans to introduce incentives for donkey-keepers in the upcoming state budget. A glimmer of hope emerges with the utilisation of donkeys as a source of dairy. At an event in Gandhinagar in November, Union minister for animal husbandry Parshottam Rupala highlighted that donkey milk commanded a market price of Rs 1,350 per litre, urging pastoralists not to abandon their animals. "Donkey milk is used in cosmetic products," he said, underlining that Amul had started procuring goat and camel milk in its cooperative model. A historical anecdote suggests Cleopatra used to bathe in donkey milk for its reputed capacity to keep skin youthful. But using donkeys as milch animals appears ambitious for now. Kapadiya says they have tried it on the government farm in Chanasma in Patan district for years, but success has been elusive. "She is a shy animal and doesn't stand for it. She kicks if anyone except her calf comes close," he says.

The export of its body parts for high-end cosmetics adds an ominous strand to the donkey economy. The absence of a formal industry in India has led to illegal trade, accentuating the threat to its survival. A report by Brooke India, an independent non-profit based in Ghaziabad, cites the illegal trafficking of donkeys for their skin as one of the key reasons for its population fall. The skin is used to make a gelatin-like substance called 'ejiao', valued for its perceived medicinal properties for the human skin and in enhancing libido in China.

In Gujarat, donkeys were traditionally reared by gypsies and other backward communities—the Vanzaras, Prajapatis and Odhs. This links the trade with caste. Over time, these communities left the animal behind as they moved up the social ladder. "The attitude of berating the donkey hasn't helped either, particularly in the rural areas," says animal geneticist Pravin Vataliya, a former vice-chancellor at Gujarat's Kamdhenu University. In Vautha, locals and officials alike deride the fair due to the caste associations and the age-old label of 'stupidity' attached to the animal. "The village hasn't benefited from it in any way. Its 3,000-odd population has no donkey traders. Plus, there's no political mileage here," says a village official. Vautha, ironically, is seeing itself as a beast of burden. While Gujarat looks to the future, the donkey could vanish off its caravan trails. ■